the next 25 years, the organisation would move fluidly between national policy advocacy and painstaking ground-up capacity-building—helping governments reform how cities are planned, built and financed.

Its first major policy breakthrough came with the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission (JNNURM), launched in 2005. The UPA government's flagship urban programme linked central funding to reforms in planning, governance and transparency. "Not many people know that JNNURM was invented by Janaagraha," says CEO Srikanth Viswanathan. The programme made people look at urban reforms more seriously and push for them.

Alongside policy, Janaagraha experimented with citizen-facing tools—platforms like 'I Paid a Bribe' and 'I Change My City'—before achieving a visible breakthrough in urban design. In 2011, its sister organisation, Jana Urban Space Foundation, introduced TenderSURE, a standardised road design that reimagined streets as public spaces. Continuous footpaths, cycle tracks, organised utility ducts—features long absent from Indian roads—suddenly became possible. Today, 174 km of TenderSURE roads operate in Bengaluru, with hundreds more under way there and across 17 towns in Uttar Pradesh.

The most consequential reform, however, came in 2020. Janaagraha's advocacy persuaded the 15th Finance Commission to make the publication of audited financial statements mandatory for urban local bodies to receive grants. The impact was far-reaching: nearly 95 per cent of India's 4,300-plus urban local bodies now publish audited accounts. Janaagraha also helped build cityfinance.in, the portal that underpins this shift.

Why does this matter? Because credible balance sheets unlock capital. "The US built its infrastructure by channelising long-term pension and insurance funds into municipal bonds," says Viswanathan. "Once data credibility improves, you will see massive changes in urban financing." By 2050, more than half of India will live in cities. For Janaagraha, there's much to be done and no time to lose. ■



STREETS REIMAGINED Srikanth Viswanathan showcases a TenderSURE street in Bengaluru

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Helped embed urban renewal into national policy, making city governance more accountable and reform-oriented**
- **Showed that working with government—without being co-opted—can make real change**
- **Strengthened tools cities need to grow sustainably through audited municipal accounts and standardised road design**